

Émile Durkheim, (born April 15, 1858, Épinal, France—died Nov. 15, 1917, Paris), French social scientist. He developed a vigorous methodology combining empirical research with sociological theory and is widely regarded as the founder of the French school of sociology.

Methodologies of Emile Durkheim:

Emile Durkheim, one of the founding figures of sociology, developed several key methodologies and concepts that are fundamental to the discipline. Here are some of the methodologies associated with Durkheim:

1. ****Social Facts****: Durkheim argued that society exerts a powerful influence on individuals, shaping their beliefs, behaviors, and values. He termed these societal influences "social facts." Durkheim believed that social facts could be studied empirically, just like physical facts.
2. ****Functionalism****: Durkheim's functionalist approach focuses on the functions that social institutions and structures serve in society. He believed that every element of society plays a role in maintaining the stability and functioning of the whole. Functionalism emphasizes the interdependence of different parts of society.
3. ****Quantitative Research****: Durkheim's work often involved quantitative analysis of social phenomena. He used statistical data to study social facts and patterns, such as suicide rates, to identify underlying social causes. His study "Suicide," published in 1897, is a classic example of his quantitative approach.
4. ****Comparative Method****: Durkheim employed a comparative method to study different societies and cultures. By comparing social phenomena across different contexts, he aimed to identify common patterns and underlying social forces that shape human behavior.
5. ****Anomie****: Durkheim introduced the concept of anomie to describe a state of normlessness or moral confusion in society. Anomie occurs when there is a disjunction between the individual's aspirations and the means available to achieve them. Durkheim explored the

relationship between anomie and social integration in his analysis of suicide.

6. ****Statistical Analysis****: Durkheim's methodologies often involved sophisticated statistical analysis to identify correlations and patterns in social data. He used statistical techniques to demonstrate the relationship between social factors and various outcomes, such as crime rates or religious participation.

7. ****Positivism****: Durkheim was influenced by positivist philosophy, which emphasizes the use of scientific methods to study social phenomena. He advocated for sociology to be treated as a science, with rigorous empirical methods and systematic analysis.

Conclusion:

These methodologies helped Durkheim make significant contributions to the field of sociology and continue to influence sociological research and theory today.

Introduction Of Suicide Theory

Durkheim on the basis of his monographic studies claims suicide as primarily a social phenomena in terms of the breakdown of the vital bond of life. Durkheim in his classical study of 'Le Suicide' which was published in 1897, demonstrates that neither psycho-pathic factor nor heredity nor climate nor poverty, nor unhappy love nor other personal factors motivate along form sufficient explanation of suicide

Durkheim has established the view that there are no societies in which suicide does not occur.

According to Durkheim, suicide is not an individual act nor a personal action. It is caused by some power which is over and above the individual or super individual. Many doctors and psychologists develop the theory that majority of people who take their own life are in a pathological state, but Durkheim emphasises that the force, which determines the suicide, is not psychological but social.

He concludes that suicide is the result of social disorganisation or lack of social integration or social solidarity.

Durkheim's Definition of Suicide

Durkheim defines suicide as a “general state of extreme depression and exaggerated sadness, causing the patient no longer to realize sanely the bonds which connect him with the people and things about him –pleasures no longer attract”

TYPES OF SUICIDE

Durkheim identifies four different types of suicide which are

**Egoistic suicide
Altruistic suicide
Anomic suicide
Fatalistic suicide**

Egoistic suicide

According to Durkheim, when a man becomes socially isolated or feels that he has no place in the society he destroys himself. This is the suicide of self-centred person who lacks altruistic feelings and is usually cut off from main stream of the society.

These individuals are unable to find their own place in society and have problems adjusting to groups. They received little and no social care. Suicide is seen as a solution for them to free themselves from loneliness or excessive individuation.

Example

When Suicide Is done by an elderly person living alone is considered as egoistic suicide

Altruistic suicide

This type of suicide occurs when individuals and the group are too close and intimate. This kind of suicide results from the over integration of the individual into social proof

Altruistic suicide occurs when social group involvement is too high. Individuals are so well integrated into the group that they are willing to sacrifice their own life in order to fulfil some obligation for the group

Individuals kill themselves for the collective benefit of the group or for the cause that the group believes in

For Example

1)An example is someone who commits suicide for the sake of a religious or political cause

2)Sati customs, Dannies warriors etc

Anomic suicide

Anomic suicide is caused by the lack of social regulation and it occurs during high levels of stress and frustration.

Anomic suicide stems from sudden and unexpected changes in situations

In simple words, Anomic suicide takes place in a situation which has cropped up suddenly.

For example

When individuals suffer extreme financial loss, the disappointment and stress that individuals face may drive them towards committing suicide as a means of escape.

Fatalistic suicide

This type of suicide is due to overregulation in society. Fatalistic suicide occurs when individuals are kept under tight regulation. These individuals are placed under extreme rules or high expectations are set upon them, which removes a person's sense of self or individuality.

For Example

Slavery and persecution are examples of fatalistic suicide where individuals may feel that they are destined by fate to be in such conditions and choose suicide as the only means of escaping such conditions

Excessive social integration
(hyper-solidarity)

Altruistic suicide
(e.g., self-sacrificial suicide)

Fatalistic suicide
(e.g., Karoshi)

Healthy circle

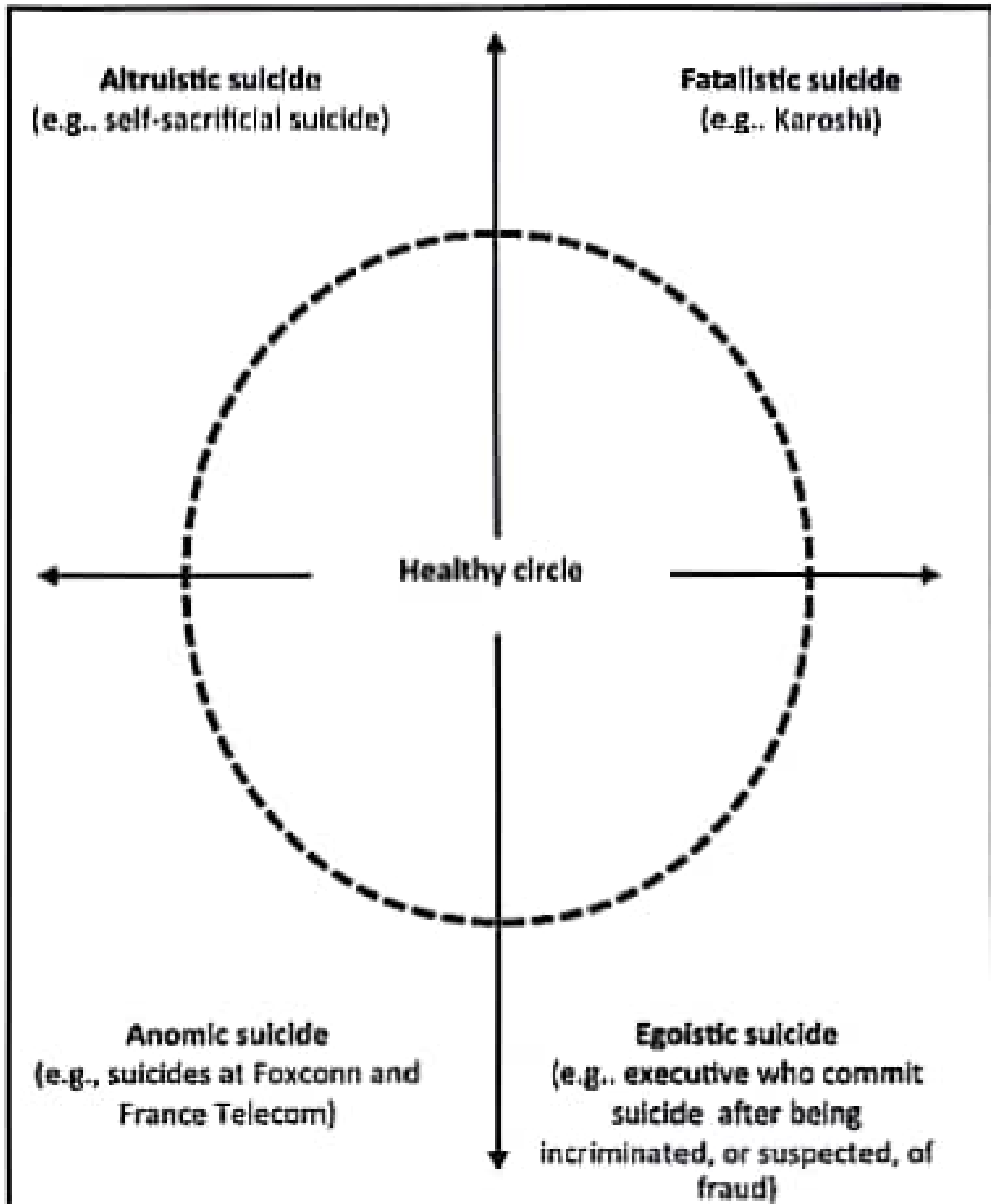
Excessive
social
regulation

Anomic suicide
(e.g., suicides at Foxconn and
France Telecom)

Egoistic suicide
(e.g., executive who commit
suicide after being
incriminated, or suspected, of
fraud)

Excessively weak social integration
(no solidarity)

Excessively
low level of
social
regulation



Theory of Religion By Emile Durkheim

Theory Of Religion

Durkheim evolved a functional explanation for the existence of religion in the world.

He observed its existence as a social fact and not as a supernatural phenomenon.

He gave the idea of religion in his work, Elementary Forms Of Religious Life 1912.

Societyopedia

Definition by DURKHEIM

Religion – A unified system of beliefs and practices related to sacred things, that is to say – things set apart and forbidden, beliefs and practices, which you need them into a single moral community, for all those who adhere to them.

Theory Of Religion

EXPLANATION OF THE DEFINITION

Beliefs – A unified system of ideas which explain the sacred, they constitute of myths, spiritual ideas, ethical code, etc.

Practices – Rites or rituals explaining individuals behaviour towards the sacred.

Positive rites – Bring individual and sacred together and are easier to perform, like worship.

Negative rites – Help in maintaining the distance between the two (individual and sacred) and keep them separated, for example, fasting and sacrifice.

Theory Of Religion

SACRED AND PROFANE

Society consists of two parts – the sacred and the profane.

The Sacred

- Things which are set apart and are forbidden.
- It includes all things which are connected to the supernatural or the divine.
- Relationship of distance and fear is maintained with the respect to these things.

Profane

- Profane are the things apart from the sacred.
- Includes day-to-day things which people use in their lives.

TOTEMISM

In this, totems are worshipped.

Totem is a representation of the clan itself.

He drew his analysis from the study of religious practices among Arunta, the Australian aboriginals.

Primitive men, when they came together for some purpose like festivals and interacted on such occasions, they felt the energy of social force.

According to primitive logic, they explain this feeling in terms of presence of some supernatural force.

Durkheim calls this height and feeling of energy generated in collective gatherings as state of exaltation or collective effervescence.

These higher forces are deemed as divine or supernatural and attributed to certain totems by the primitive tribes.

They create a totem to represent and regain that feeling.

The totems are the material representations of the non-material force that is at their base and that non-material force is none other than the society itself.

The feeling which was due to the feeling of being together, was instead, interpreted as The Sacred. So, totem is a symbol of collectivity or the symbol of society itself.

Origin of Religion

Primitive People
were wanders



Occasionally came
Together



Need to experience
that feeling



State of Exaltation



Creation of totem



Root cause of
religion

Religion And Society

Durkheim asks 'If it is at once the symbol of God and Society, is it not because God and Society are one and same'?

Religious experiences are real experiences of social forces, forces that unite us.

Social obligations are represented in sacred terms and hence transform into religious duties. Eg: Marriage becomes a sacrament.

Religion is also a social fact.
It performs the function of bringing people together.

Criticism

- The dichotomy of profane and sacred is not absolute and there can be 'things' also as per William Edward Stanner.
- Durkheim did not explain why a particular totem is chosen.
- Criticized for being an armchair theory.
- Generalisation of primitive religion to modern sophisticated religion is a farfetched view.
- Scholars argue that it is not religion but secularism which is binding the societies together in modern industrialised societies.
- Fails to explain the cause of solidarity in multicultural polytheistic societies like India.
- Focused only on functional aspects and ignored the conflict caused by religion.

Division of Labour In Society

By Emile Durkheim

Division of Labour

Def :

Division of Labour is the separation of a work process into a number of tasks, with each task performed by a separate person or group of persons.

The specialisation of task is known as division of Labour.

Example :

Food production

A very basic example of division of labour could be seen in food gathering. In early societies, men would be the hunters, women and children would prepare the food and collect berries. The idea was that it was a very simple division of labour to enable the best use of different skill sets.

Factory

Workers, supervisor, manager

Government

PM, Home minister, Defense Minister

Division of Labour

Durkheim's first major work, *The Division of Labor in Society* (1893), which was based on his doctoral dissertation, Durkheim explains how the division of labor (or economic specialization) characteristic of modern society

Durkheim argued that economic specialization was not necessarily "bad" for either the individual or the society as a whole. Instead, he argued that an extensive division of labor could exist without necessarily jeopardizing the moral cohesion of a society or the opportunity for individuals to realize their interests affects individuals as well as society as a whole.

Durkheim's concept of the division of labor focused on the shift in societies from a simple society to one that is more complex. He argued that traditional societies were made up of homogenous people that were more or less the same in terms of values, religious beliefs, and backgrounds. Modern societies, in contrast, are made up of a complex division of labor, beliefs, and backgrounds.

In traditional societies, the collective consciousness ruled, social norms were strong, and social behavior was well regulated. In modern societies, common consciousness was less obvious, and the regulation of social behavior was less punitive and more restitutive, aiming to restore normal activity to society.

Emile Durkheim" belonged to the structural-functional school of thought. He was interested in the study of social structure and its functions. How different part of society function and contribute to the functioning of society as whole. He believed that social solidarity is the main element which hold society together. Social solidarity is the feeling of unity among individuals with one another and with society or what makes society solid, viable and hold it together. He explained solidarity in two different type of societies. He says that, mechanical solidarity exist in a societies which has simple social structure like rural society. Whereas organic solidarity exist in the society which has complex social structure like urban society.

Division of Labour

What holds Society Together ?



Social Solidarity

Durkheim explained two types of Social Solidarity that exist in Society

- 1) Mechanical Solidarity
- 2) Organic Solidarity

Durkheim classified solidarity in primitive and modern societies on the basis of similarities and specialisations

According to E.D, Primitive and simple societies have Mechanical Solidarity whereas modern and complex societies have Organic Solidarity.

Mechanical Solidarity

According to “Emile Durkheim”, traditional societies or rural societies has mechanical solidarity. Individuals bond together in traditional society by the homogeneity. The division of labor is very slight in this type of society. Individual almost have similar skill sets and have similar job responsibilities. In traditional society individuals earn their livelihood from agriculture and in agriculture societies there is very low division of labor almost every individual is peasant. Moreover, people of rural society share similar religion, culture, norms, believes and values. Due to the homogeneity they are connected with one another and society, which is characterized by, “Emile Durkheim” as mechanical solidarity. Mechanical solidarity is based on the sameness of people living in a society. Emile Durkheim built an analogy which compare a society with a machine or a series of machines which are manufactured similarly. Suppose if there is a problem in a part of machine because of which machine is not working. It can be replaced by the same part of other machine and it will start working again. By this analogy Durkheim was trying to prove that, traditional or rural societies are held together by homogeneity.

Organic solidarity

Emile Durkheim believed that, modern industrial societies has organic solidarity. Individuals in modern bond together by heterogeneity. In urban society division of labor is very high; every individual possess different skill set or specialization. Moreover, individuals dissimilar, religion, believes, values norm and culture. So the logic dictated question arises here that, what hold them together? The answer is interdependence. Individuals in urban society are dependent on each other because of high division of labor, they trade their skills with one another which connects them with each other. Suppose if someone need legal assistance he will hire a lawyer, if someone car is broke he will go to mechanic for repair and if someone need hair cut he will go to barber. Individuals in urban society rely on each other that is what unify them. Emile Durkheim compared modern societies with organism, which are composed of multiple organ and each organ has its specialized function, organism is healthy if each part or organ perform its function. Similarly, modern society are composed of multiple institutions and each has its own specialized function if each individual and institution perform its function then it will result in healthy society.

Difference between Organic and mechanical solidarity

Mechanical Solidarity

Mechanical solidarity is a result of similarities between members of a society.

Seen in Traditional societies.

Minimum division of Labor

Less specialisation of task.

Everyone has to perform various tasks.

Less interdependence.

Organic Solidarity

Organic solidarity is a result of the interdependence among members of a society.

Seen in modern societies.

Complex division of Labor

More specialisation of task.

Everyone performs a specific task.

More interdependence

Social Facts By Emile Durkheim

According to Emile Durkheim, a social fact is an abstract instance that shapes social behaviors. The idea behind this quote is that one should not center itself on the perceived consequences, but on what allows, forces, or drives those consequences. This can be social institutions, cultural determinants, etc.

For instances suicide is not a social fact on itself. Rather, certain aspects of a culture and of a way of life drive suicide, so the social fact is the communitarian nature of catholicism, or the lonesome competition resulting from a market economy, or the fatalistic melancholy of an oppressive and overly determinant authority.

What is Social Facts ?

Social facts in sociology was introduced by Emile Durkheim. Social facts are basically cultural norms and values and social structures present in a given society.

For example : Religion.

Social facts have the power to shape the conduct of individuals. It can control your actions and shape your behaviour. I'll explain with the help of an example. Take religion, every religion wants us to behave in a certain way. Different religions have different rituals for different occasions. It has specific norms that all followers need to comply to.

The meaning of social in 'social facts' is that their source is not in the individual, their substratum can be no other than society.

Social facts are believed by the society. Our behaviour is caused by the social facts.

Society is not just collection of an individuals. Society really exists a social fact can change the individual behaviour.

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Features of Social Facts

- 1) Social facts exist outside the individual.
- 2) Social facts have coercive power.
- 3) They must be studied as things and scientific method must be employed to study them.

Example of social facts

Marriage: There are certain norms in different societies related to marriage. For eg: Monogamy, Polygamy, Polyandre etc. When these are not followed people experience the coercive power of social facts.

Religion: Various religions have certain practices associated with them and the sociologist need to study them objectively

Why study social facts?

Because Durkheim sees two sort of them:

- The normal ones, that drive the maintenance of daily routines, orders, and social life.
- The Pathological ones, that drive consequences that might disrupt individual and collective wellbeing, and endanger the sustainability of a society.

The study of social facts ought to help find the later and prevent them.

Types of Social Facts

Two types of social facts are material and non-material social facts.

- Material social facts are features of society such as social structures and institutions.
- Nonmaterial social facts are social facts which do not have a material reality. They consist of features such as norms, values, and systems of morality.

Characteristics of Social Facts

- 1) Externality
- 2) Constraints
- 3) Generality
- 4) Independent